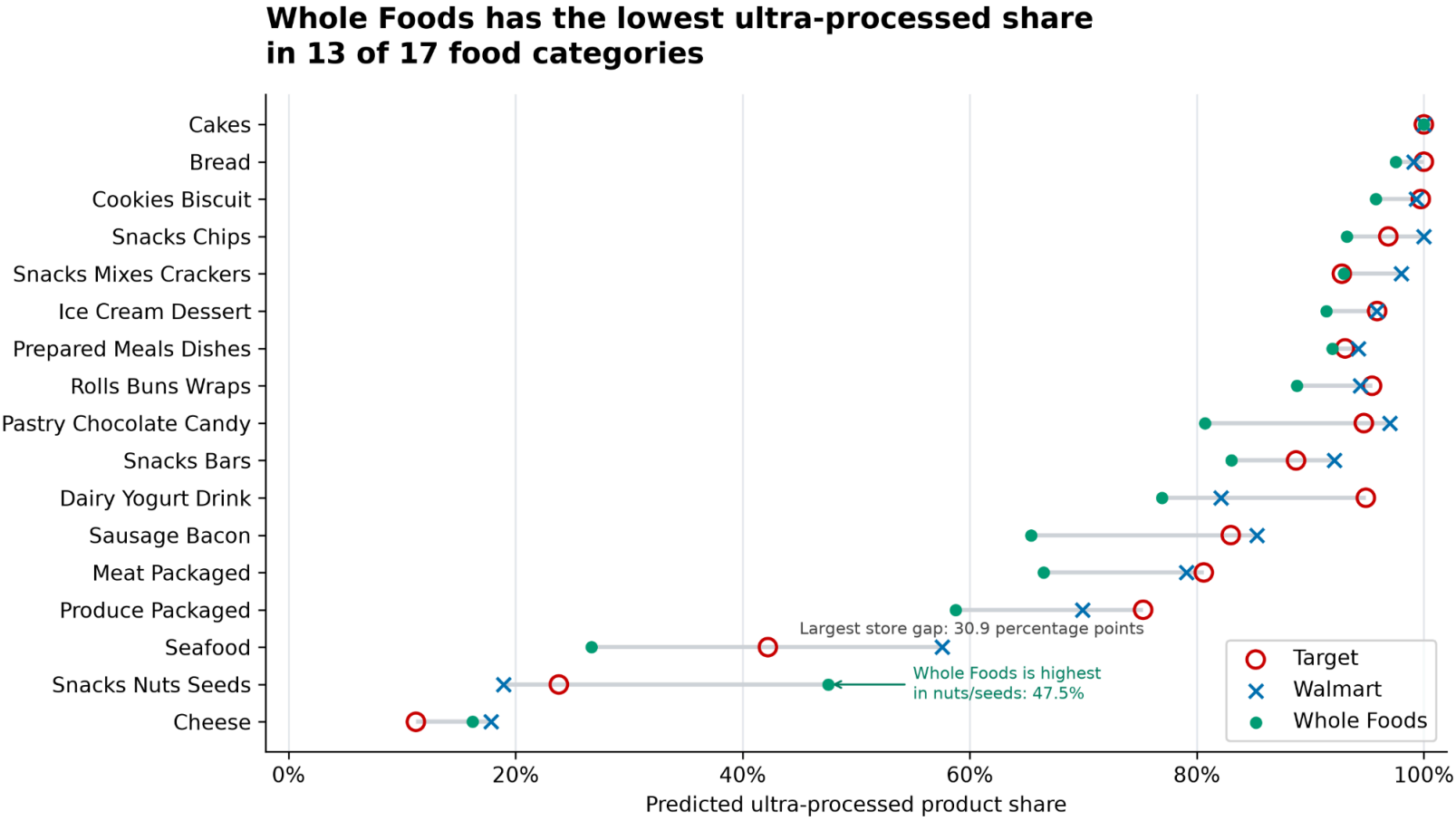


Source: GroceryDB. Ultra-processed = predicted FPro_class 3.
Exact duplicates removed; each category has at least 100 records per store.
Shares describe product records, not sales or consumption.

I was curious whether supermarket differences would still show up when comparing the same types of food. This figure compares the share of predicted ultra-processed products at Target, Walmart, and Whole Foods within 17 food categories. Overall, Whole Foods has a lower share than the other two stores in 13 categories, but the size and direction are different. Seafood has the largest gap, with a 30.9 percentage-point gap between Whole Foods and Walmart. Nuts and seeds caught my attention because the pattern reverses: Whole Foods has the highest share at 47.5%, compared with 23.8% at Target and 18.9% at Walmart.

I treated records with a predicted FPro_class of 3 as ultra-processed. I removed exact duplicate rows, then divided the number of ultra-processed records by the total number of records within each category-store group and multiplied by 100. Percentages make groups with different record counts easier to compare. I kept categories with at least 100 records in each store, leaving 17 categories. I chose this threshold to avoid comparisons based on very small groups; it also means the findings apply to a selected subset of categories.

Because the food categories have long names and I wanted readers to compare the three stores within each row so I chose a horizontal dot plot. Horizontal position shows the percentage on a shared scale, while vertical position identifies the food category. Red hollow circles represent Target, blue crosses represent Walmart, and green filled circles represent Whole Foods. The distinct colors make each store easy to follow, and the different shapes help readers distinguish overlapping values and identify stores in ways beyond color. Light gray lines connect the minimum and maximum shares within each category, making larger store differences easier to spot. I sorted categories by their unweighted mean share across the three stores to organize the overall distribution.

The title states the main finding, and the two annotations point out the largest store gap and the reversal in nuts and seeds. I used green for the nuts-and-seeds annotation to connect it visually with Whole Foods, which helps readers notice both the general pattern and an exception. However, the percentages describe product records in this dataset, rather than sales or actual consumption. Products within the same broad category can also differ across stores, and the processing classifications are predictions. The figure shows differences in the recorded product selections, without establishing nutritional quality or the health effects of shopping at a particular store.